NOCTURNE

After a public scandal shatters her life, a disgraced Japanese heiress hires a secretive organization called the Night Movers to help her disappear—only to discover she was never meant to survive the process, and must unravel a conspiracy of erotic control, corporate erasure, and manufactured shame before she’s permanently rewritten.

Written by

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Address

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FADE IN:

INT. PROFESSOR SHIN'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

A sparse, modern Tokyo high-rise. Concrete, teak, and tension.

A single table is set for two. Two ceramic bowls of curry steam quietly. A bottle of sake breathes.

AKIRA (26) sits with her legs crossed, posture precise. Not nervous. Not at ease. Her lipstick is too dark for the room.

Across from her, PROFESSOR SHIN (40s). Married. Respected. Calm in the way men are when they've never been truly cornered.

They eat in silence. The hum of a distant city rolls through the window.

He refills her sake without asking.

AKIRA
You don't have to pretend we're equals when you pour.

SHIN
I'm not pretending.

She chews. He watches.

AKIRA
You heard what they're saying.

SHIN
They always say something.

AKIRA
You didn't deny it.

SHIN
(smiling, small)
That's not the same as confirming.

A silence thickens between them. Akira looks down. Steam fogs her glasses.

She pushes her food around. Doesn't eat.

SHIN (CONT'D)
I always liked how you ask questions like you already know the answer.

AKIRA
I already know what I'm worth to you.

SHIN
That's not fair.

AKIRA
That's not a denial.

A beat. He reaches across the table. Gently wipes a drop of curry from her lip with his thumb.

She doesn't flinch.

SHIN
You should learn to keep secrets if you want to stay important.

He smiles like he's offering advice. Not drawing blood.

Akira's eyes glass, but never break.

INT. AKIRA'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

CLOSE ON, Her fingers opening a folder. Confidential documents. Names. Financials. Transfers.

She slides them into a scanner. Her movements are slow. Controlled.

She opens her email. No subject line. No message body. Just an attachment and a recipient.

A SOUND, barely audible. A LAUGH.

YOUNG GIRL (O.S.)
(laughing)
You always said I'd disappear first.

FLASH: A SLIVER OF MEMORY.

Two girls. Barefoot in a summer creek. Late afternoon light. One chases the other. Breathless joy. Water everywhere.

BACK- Akira stares at the screen. Still.

Her mouse hovers over SEND. Eyes, welling slightly.

The laugh echoes in silence.

A flicker in the dark screen, not a reflection. A braid. A shape. Gone before she registers it.

She closes her eyes.

AKIRA (V.O.)
I wanted to be believed.
(beat)
But more than that, I wanted to be impossible to ignore.

She clicks.

INT. BATHROOM - NIGHT

She holds a match to the folder. The flame climbs fast.

She drops it in the sink. Watches it blacken, curl, choke.

The room fills with smoke.

Her face never changes.

SMASH CUT TO:

EXT. TOKYO - NIGHT

We are back with her, BAREFOOT, walking alone, neon sliding off her wet skin.

CUT TO:

INT. TRAIN STATION - BATHROOM - NIGHT

Harsh lights. Echoed emptiness. Akira stands in front of the mirror. Her reflection barely holds.

She peels off her coat. Opens her blouse. Beneath, a long scar traces the underside of her ribs.

She traces it with her fingers. Not ashamed. Not proud. Just checking if it’s still there.

CUT TO:

INT. SUBWAY CAR - NIGHT

Akira sits alone. Lights flicker above, a stuttering rhythm, like a failing heartbeat.

Her face reflected in the glass, pale, flickering, like it's already vanishing.

She studies her own eyes. Trying to remember them. Or forget them.

Her jaw tightens. Hands curl into fists on her lap.

The lights flutter again and for a second, it's like someone else is staring back.

A fracture.

Something stirs behind her eyes, vulnerable, unspoken. The smallest ghost of a tear that never comes.

She blinks. Mask on. Armor reset.

The train pulls forward.

And she goes with it.

CUT TO:

EXT. NOCTURNE LTD. HEADQUARTERS - LATER

A nondescript building. Corporate. Forgettable.

She stands outside, soaked, staring at the entrance like it's a coffin, or a door she won't return from.

She presses the buzzer.

A VOICE (O.S.)
Name?

AKIRA
Akira Kawasaki.

The door clicks open.

INT. FACILITY - LOBBY - NIGHT

Fluorescent. Cold. No reception desk.

REI MIKAMI (30s) waits in a pressed suit. Pen in hand. Notebook open. The smile he gives her is thin. Professional.

Akira steps inside.

Her eyes flick to the WALL-MOUNTED DISPLAY — a looped digital welcome screen glitches faintly.

INSERT — THE SCREEN:

WELCOME TO NOCTURNE LTD.

PARTICIPATION IS VOLUNTARY.

NOCTURNE LTD. IS NOT LIABLE UNDER NATIONAL OR INTERNATIONAL JURISDICTION.

Below it, faintly etched in the glass beneath the screen, a worn government seal, partially scraped off. As if someone tried to erase history... but didn’t finish.

Akira’s eyes linger on it.

REI
You’re on time.

Akira nods. Doesn’t sit.

AKIRA
What happens now?

REI
We begin.

He clicks his pen. The sound echoes.

A flicker on a wall-mounted display. For a split second a black glyph, ancient and insect-like, flashes across the screen:骸会.

Akira tenses. Eyes narrow, not recognition, but the instinct to.

She catches a glance in Rei’s eyes, something small and guarded. He masks it, too late.

REI (CONT’D)
Ignore that.
(beat)
Just legacy code. Old systems still bleeding through.

The screen clears. Clean corporate blue.

Akira says nothing. But she’s seen it.

INT. FACILITY - HALLWAY - MOMENTS LATER

Long corridor. White tile, stainless steel. The buzz of electricity hums beneath the silence.

Akira walks beside Rei. Their footsteps do not echo. This place was built not to be remembered.

REI
Phones. Wallet. Identification.

Akira hands him everything without protest. Even the necklace. A tiny jade cicada. He clocks it.

REI (CONT'D)
Sentimental?

AKIRA
It was my sister's.

REI
Not anymore.

He drops it into a plastic envelope. Seals it.

They walk. Another door hisses open without being touched.

INT. INDUCTION ROOM - NIGHT

A room meant to look medical but not sterile. That same cold-warm confusion found in hotels and funeral homes.

YUMI TAKEDA (late 20s) stands behind a terminal. Unsmiling. Her hair is too neat. Her nails too clean.

YUMI
Strip down to underclothes.

Akira doesn't move.

YUMI (CONT'D)
I assume you read the packet.

AKIRA
I read it.

YUMI
Then you know what we need.

Akira takes her time. Blazer. Blouse. Skirt. Each item folded precisely and laid on the chair.

REI
We ask for no lies here. Only the self you intend to kill.

Akira meets his gaze. Cold. Furious. And afraid.

AKIRA
You want a confession?

YUMI
No. We want your permission.

Beat.

Akira nods once. Yumi steps forward with a scanner. Moves it over Akira’s body.

The screen behind her flickers with pulsing lines. Brainwave graphs. Thermal overlays. Lines of kanji auto-populate in red.

YUMI (CONT’D)
No pacemaker. No pregnancy. No record of psychiatric detainment.

REI
Physical trauma. Lower left thoracic scarring.

AKIRA
Knife.

YUMI
Yours?

AKIRA
(a breath)
No.

Yumi doesn't write it down. She already knows it doesn't matter.

REI
Akira Kawasaki. Final request confirmed.

He slides a folder toward her. Thick. Paper clipped.

REI (CONT’D)
Sign and thumbprint. You may choose to speak a final sentence into record.

Akira flips through it. Her eyes pause at one section: MOTIVE.

Her pen hovers.

AKIRA
I was the wrong story in the right family.

She signs. Presses her thumb.

Yumi clicks something. The lights shift cooler.

YUMI
Transfer begins now.

A door slides open behind them. Faint sound of rain. But no exit sign. No escape.

Akira walks forward, doesn't look back.

CUT TO:

INT. OBSERVATION SUITE - NIGHT

A bank of monitors. Yumi and Rei watch Akira disappear into the corridor beyond.

The feed flickers. Soundless. Akira, shrinking into the vanishing point.

YUMI
She doesn't know.

REI
None of them do.

Yumi closes the terminal. Her hand lingers, a moment too long.

A flicker of something in her eyes. Not regret. Not nostalgia. Just the memory of having once been breakable.

YUMI
(soft)
I was like you once.

Rei looks over. Caught off guard.

YUMI (CONT'D)
Before I chose.

She exhales. Faint. Controlled.

YUMI (CONT'D)
They say fear makes you human. But it's obedience that makes you stay that way.

Rei doesn’t respond. He’s not sure if it’s a warning. Or a confession.

The monitors buzz quietly.

YUMI (CONT’D)
Good.

She turns. Walks out, leaving only static behind.

CUT TO:

INT. TRANSFER CORRIDOR - NIGHT

Dim, narrow. Metallic hum. The hallway feels endless, a tunnel of waiting.

Akira walks, flanked by two silent attendants. No words exchanged.

Up ahead, another subject. Male. Mid-30s. SWEATING. SHAKING.

He looks over his shoulder, sees Akira, and SNAPS.

SUBJECT
No—NO! This isn't what they said!

He SPINS, lands a brutal elbow into one attendant’s throat. The man crumples.

Chaos erupts. Screams echo down the corridor. A security strobe hits, harsh, white, pulsing.

The other attendant tackles the subject, fists flying. A syringe hits the floor. Shatters.

Akira stops.

Unmoving. Watching.

The subject locks eyes with her. Bloody. Wild.

SUBJECT (CONT’D)
Don’t let them—

He’s yanked backward and out of frame. His scream cuts off.

Silence returns. Except for the hum.

Akira blinks. And keeps walking.

A DOOR opens ahead. Swallowing her.

CUT TO:

INT. ORIENTATION ROOM - NIGHT

Clinical. Soundproofed. Faux warmth. Soft earth-toned walls, artificial plants. A screen blinks on the far wall, a corporate video frozen mid-frame. The hum of the fluorescent lights is the only soundtrack, dull and constant, like the inside of a machine.

Akira sits alone at a round table. Her posture is perfect, but her hands are trembling under the table. A SINGLE CAMERA blinks red above her, cyclopean and patient.

REI (O.S.)
When you're ready, Ms. Kawasaki.

Akira exhales, steadying her breath. Her voice is flat, almost like reading a script.

AKIRA
My name is Akira Kawasaki. I am willingly undergoing voluntary relocation under the protections of Nocturne Ltd.

Akira hesitates.

REI (O.S.)
Please proceed.

She does. Her voice falters now, but she continues.

AKIRA
I relinquish legal identity, familial ties, and all forms of digital presence...

Behind her, the WHISPER. It’s her sister’s laugh. A memory long buried. Soft. Playful. It doesn't belong here.

Akira turns, reflexive. The room is still.

INT. COMMON ROOM - LATER

A cafeteria space. Pale wood. Soft music filtered through speakers recessed in the ceiling. Everything is a little too clean. People sit in groups of twos and threes. Smiling. Too still.

Akira enters. Her shoes make no sound against the vinyl floor. The room registers her presence, but no one looks.

Yumi steps forward from the corner, like she was waiting for this moment.

YUMI
Relax. They're friendly, in theory.

Akira doesn’t laugh.

AKIRA
Do they speak?

YUMI
Only if you already know what they'll say.

Yumi leads her to a small circular table. At it, a WOMAN (20s, polite, pretty, blank) sits with her hands folded neatly in her lap.

WOMAN
Relocation due to stalker harassment. Duration, indefinite.

She smiles. Perfect. Hollow.

WOMAN (CONT’D)
I’m grateful to be here.

Akira nods. Her breath catches.

As Yumi moves behind the woman just for a beat. The woman’s lips shift, a whisper, barely audible.

WOMAN (CONT’D)
(whispers)
Get out, they’re MUKUROKAI.

Akira freezes. The woman’s eyes don’t move. Her smile resumes, as if it never left.

INT. HALLWAY - NIGHT

Long. Endless. Fluorescent glow. The hum returns. Akira walks alone. Her shadow splits and elongates.

Rei stands to the side, back to her, facing a panel. His body is stiff. He’s listening to something on a hidden earpiece.

CHILD'S VOICE (VOICEMAIL)
Did I do good, Papa?

He deletes it instantly as he notices her. Turns. Their eyes meet, something unspoken and raw flickers across his face.

REI
You're not cleared for that wing.

AKIRA
Then you should lock it.

A flash of restraint behind Rei's eyes. Something pulled tight, then buried.

He says nothing. She moves past.

INT. REASSIGNMENT ROOM - NIGHT

White. Endless. A standing mirror with no reflection. Or maybe it's just too clean. Too still.

Yumi enters holding a thin black file. She doesn't sit. She doesn't blink much.

YUMI
Effective immediately, you are Shiori Takada. Age, twenty-seven. Primary vulnerability, abandonment anxiety. Assigned field, art handler. Residence, Unit A-713.

The file opens like a ritual. Akira's hands shake slightly as she takes it. Inside: an ID card. Passport. Lease. All pristine. All official.

AKIRA
Primary vulnerability, sounds clinical.

YUMI
It is. The algorithm is impersonal by design.

A beat. A flicker of anger under Akira's eyes.

AKIRA
So I'm a liability profile.

YUMI
No. You're a forecast.

Their fingers brush as Yumi passes the last document. The contact is brief, but electric. Charged.

INT. THE WHISPER ROOM - NIGHT

A small booth. Eggshell walls. No mirrors. No visible surveillance. But there's the sense of being watched from inside your own skin.

Akira steps in. The door seals behind her with a pneumatic hiss.

The ceiling light dims.

A speaker embedded somewhere in the walls crackles softly.

First: SHIN'S VOICE.

SHIN (V.O.)
You should learn to keep secrets...

She winces.

Then: her sister.

SISTER (V.O.)
Did you forget me?

A low-frequency hum begins. Deep. Vibrational. Her fingernails twitch involuntarily.

She scratches at her scar. Harder now. Breath short.

Then, a third voice. Genderless. Timeless. Something inhuman...

VOICE (V.O.)
MUKUROKAI is watching.

It sounds like it's coming from inside her own lungs.

Her body tightens. She presses her hands over her ears, but the sound is not in the room. It's in her.

The tone escalates. Not louder, deeper. Molecular.

Then-

Silence.

The door slides open.

Yumi stands there, immaculate. The hallway behind her is a tomb.

YUMI
Longer than most.

Akira says nothing. She steps out.

CUT TO:

INT. TRANSITION CHAMBER - NIGHT

A narrow room of obsidian black. No walls, only reflections. The floor pulses faintly beneath Akira's feet, like it's breathing.

A HUM builds from the walls. Not mechanical. Organic. Like a throat clearing.

Yumi stands across from her. No file this time. Just her presence, like fog. Soft, creeping, cold at the bone.

YUMI
Final clearance requires silence.

AKIRA
I thought I passed.

YUMI
That was compliance. This is surrender.

Akira meets her gaze. Something in her wants to fight. Something else wants to disappear.

YUMI (CONT'D)
Step forward.

Akira does. The HUM deepens. Her reflection flickers.

YUMI (CONT'D)
Name?

AKIRA
Akira Kawasaki.

YUMI
No. Name?

A beat.

AKIRA
Shiori Takada.

YUMI
Purpose?

AKIRA
To be forgotten.

The HUM stops.

In the silence: her heartbeat. A flutter. Then stillness.

Yumi steps forward. Touches Akira's forehead with two fingers. A gesture that feels like anointing. Or branding.

YUMI (SOFT)
Welcome home.

INT. SURVEILLANCE ROOM - NIGHT

Banks of monitors. Silent. A vast grid of faces in hallways, bedrooms, restrooms.

Rei stands in the dark. Only the glow of the screens illuminate his face.

He watches Akira.

YUMI (V.O.)
You feel it too, don’t you? Like gravity... bending toward her.

Rei flinches.

YUMI (V.O.)
She breaks rules just by existing.

He zooms in on her face. Frame by frame.

CLOSE ON: Her lips. Slightly parted. Not afraid. Not yet.

He turns the screen off.

INT. AKIRA'S ASSIGNED APARTMENT - NIGHT

Spartan. Too clean. Generic feminine touches applied like paint. A silk scarf draped, a pink toothbrush, a photo of friends she doesn't know.

Akira sits on the bed, still clothed. The ID card in her hand. The name SHIORI TAKADA etched in flawless Helvetica.

She runs her thumb across it. Again. And again.

She breathes.

INT. SHARED HALLWAY - CONTINUOUS

Yumi stands outside Akira’s door. Listening.

Her fingers twitch once.

She walks away.

CUT TO:

INT. SURVEILLANCE ROOM - NIGHT

Dim blue glow. Monitors hum, casting ghostlight across Rei's face. Alone, back stiff, eyes locked on one screen.

ON SCREEN: AKIRA sleeps, barely. Curled on her side, ID card clutched in her hand. Stillness so pure it looks posed.

Rei scrubs back the footage. Slower now. Frame by frame.

A FLICKER.

Behind her, a SHADOW. No movement. Just a shape where no shape should be.

He freezes the frame.

ZOOMS IN. Enhances. Grain explodes. It's nothing.

Except, her reflection in the dark glass behind the bed...

It's facing the camera.

REI
(murmurs)
No timestamp anomaly... No entry log...

He taps a key.

Encrypts the file. Labels it: CAT R - 01 / Echo.

CUT TO:

INT. DIAGNOSTIC LAB - NIGHT

Banks of data streams. Pulse charts. Deep mind scans rendered in shifting waves.

The lab hums with a synthetic stillness, lights too white, air too quiet.

Yumi stands alone, surrounded by screens. She scrolls through Akira's WHISPER ROOM neural feedback.

CLICK. CLICK. Two files overlay, one from the session, one archival.

ON-SCREEN: Akira's scan. Complex. Unstable. But beneath it, something too ordered. Too clean.

An emergent symmetry.

YUMI
(quietly)
That's not... possible.

She pinches to isolate the waveform.

The monitor glitches. Resolves.

INSERT: An abstract symbol emerges embedded in the EEG output. 黒神 KUROKAMI.

Yumi doesn't breathe. She stares.

A TECHNICIAN (20s) enters quietly. Freezes when he sees the screen.

TECHNICIAN
That embedded? That's not supposed to—

YUMI
No one added it.
(beat)
It's recursive. Self-generating.

She tilts her head slightly. Eyes narrowing.

YUMI (CONT'D) (CONT'D)
What's the control signature?

TECHNICIAN
(shaking his head)
No metadata. It's clean. Like it generated from inside.

Yumi's fingers hover over the waveform.

She magnifies it.

INSERT: The signal pulses in triplets. Rhythmic. Inverted tones, like a melody being played backwards.

The symbol pulses in rhythm, not chaotic. Composed. Almost... elegant.

TECHNICIAN (CONT'D)
Is that from her?

YUMI
I've seen this before.
(beat)
But it never stabilized. They all broke apart. It's not supposed to survive iteration.
(beat)
It's flagged in... legacy audits.

She clicks deeper.

Files open. Redacted pages. A glimpse of a pattern. Old intakes. Protocols long archived. One word unblurred: MUKUROKAI.

YUMI (CONT'D)
(whispered)
Mukurokai... Not again.

The technician backs away slightly.

TECHNICIAN
Should I report this to Tier One?

Yumi slowly turns to face him. Her expression is unreadable. Eyes calculating.

YUMI
No.
(beat)
It's an artifact.
(pause)
A ghost in the machine.

TECHNICIAN
But what if it's not—

YUMI
Then we're all obsolete.

She closes the terminal with a soft, final gesture.

CUT TO:

INT. AKIRA'S ROOM - NIGHT

Dark. Only streetlight through blinds. Akira lies still on her bed.

CLOSE ON: Her eyes, OPEN NOW.

Something BUZZES faintly. The hum of fluorescent decay? Or something inside the walls?

She sits up.

On her nightstand, the jade cicada. Burnt. Ashed around the edges.

She stares.

Blink.

It’s gone.

She breathes in sharply, heartbeat spiking.

The FRIEND PHOTO on the wall FLICKERS.

The people inside shift positions. Turn their heads toward her. Blink.

WHISPER (V.O.)
You brought it back.

Akira backs away. Her scar throbs under her shirt.

INT. BATHROOM - CONTINUOUS

She flicks on the light.

Looks in the mirror-

Her reflection STARES BACK, but not synchronously. It’s delayed.

Then, the reflection BLINKS.

AKIRA (V.O.)
I didn’t call anything...

Her reflection SMILES.

The mirror CRACKS.

CUT TO:

INT. MAINTENANCE CORRIDOR - NIGHT

Harsh overhead lights. Metal underfoot. Yumi and Rei face each other in near silence.

YUMI
You pulled her footage.

REI
It flagged itself.

YUMI
She’s carrying something. Or...
something’s carrying her.

Rei glances at the security feed. Akira’s room now dark again. Still. Normal.

REI
Terminate transfer?

YUMI
No. We observe. She’s already
opening it.

REI
Opening what?

Yumi doesn’t answer.

The lights FLICKER. Buzz.

A soft, rhythmic HUM builds in the corridor walls.

Then stops.

CUT TO:

INT. SURVEILLANCE ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

The CAMERA FEED. Akira, sitting up now. Eyes locked forward.

She turns slowly, makes direct eye contact with the surveillance cam.

CLOSE ON. Her eyes. Reflective. Bottomless.

For a single frame, they go fully black.

The screen cuts to static.

CUT TO:

INT. CONTAINMENT BAY - NIGHT

Dimly lit. Clinical. Humming machinery and chilled silence. Rows of black monitors line the walls. Red indicator lights pulse like a slow heartbeat.

A corrupted feed plays on REI's monitor. It skips, stutters, pixelates.

CLOSE ON: The image. Akira, in her room. Her eyes lock onto the camera. Her pupils flood black.

Then- static.

Rei watches. Stone still. He plays the clip again. Same glitch. Same stare. Same collapse.

YUMI (O.S.)
You've played it seven times.

Rei doesn't turn. Her reflection appears faintly in the monitor.

REI
It isn't possible.

YUMI
None of this is. That's not the point.

She steps beside him, gaze locked to the broken feed. Her face is unreadable, a calm mask held tight over panic.

YUMI (CONT'D)
It's her. She's the breach.

REI
We screened her. We wrote her.

YUMI
No. We projected. You can't edit what you don't understand.

Rei slowly turns to her. Voice low.

REI
Then what the fuck is she?

Yumi's silence is loaded. She speaks it like a secret a name not spoken aloud in years.

YUMI
Mukurokai used to have another name for this. Before the cleanrooms and contracts.

A beat.

YUMI (CONT'D)
Kurokami.

That word lands like a rupture. Rei's breath shortens.

REI
That's just folklore. A myth stitched into training material to scare off conscience.

YUMI
Or a memory.

She turns toward the hallway. The light above them flickers.

YUMI (CONT'D)
Prep Chamber Three. No assistants. No preamble.

REI
You want to go in alone?

YUMI
I need to see what's left. Of her. Of us.

She exits. The monitor loops again, Akira's eyes, that stare ... static.

SMASH TO:

INT. INTERVIEW CHAMBER - NIGHT

Sealed. Windowless. A single bulb swings above a sterile steel table. Two chairs. Two lives.

Yumi enters. Alone. She closes the door behind her like a confession.

On the far side of the table, Akira. Already seated. Still. Awake.

The light flickers. Her hands are folded. Her posture calm, but her eyes scan Yumi like a scalpel.

YUMI
You didn’t sleep.

AKIRA
I wasn’t invited to.

A long silence. Yumi sits slowly. Puts a black folder on the table. Doesn’t open it.

YUMI
Do you know why you’re here?

AKIRA
Because I stared too long.

Yumi hesitates, then smiles. Brief. Pained.

YUMI
Because something’s staring back.

The room tightens. The hum of the overhead bulb now a drill inside the silence.

AKIRA
What is this place really?

YUMI
A chrysalis. A crime scene. A correction.

AKIRA
Or a cage?

YUMI
Only if you remember the outside.

They hold each other’s gaze. The air thickens. Something unspoken growing between them.

AKIRA
I saw it. In the mirror.

YUMI
What did you see?

AKIRA
Not me. Not her. But something waiting to take shape.

Yumi leans forward. Her voice lowers, almost tender.

YUMI
They used to say Kurokami wore a woman's face. When the world forgot how to mourn.

Akira doesn't blink.

AKIRA
Do you think that's me?

YUMI
I think you're remembering what we erased.

Akira smiles now. Not soft. Something sharp, and almost holy.

AKIRA
Then you should've done a better job.

CUT TO:

INT. OBSERVATION CORRIDOR - NIGHT

Dimly lit. Security glass stretches the length of the hall. Behind it: identical rooms, each sealed, staged, silent. Lives paused mid-edit.

Rei leans against the glass, arms folded. A cigarette dangles, unlit. A flick of hesitation in his thumb. He doesn't light it.

Yumi approaches from behind. Silent as breath.

YUMI
You still think she's just breaking down?

REI
No.

YUMI
Then what?

REI
Breaking through.

Yumi joins him at the glass. Their reflections float above the image of Akira, projected live, sitting again on her bed. Still. Alert.

REI (CONT'D)
Every subject glitches. Dream spill, pattern recognition, bleed-through. That's protocol. But her?

YUMI
She's recursive. She looks back.

REI
She recognized the surveillance. Didn't pretend she didn't.

YUMI
(small)
She saw me.

Rei turns to her.

REI
You think she knows who you were?

Yumi doesn't answer. Her hand touches the glass, not Akira's cell, but the one beside it. Empty. The interior charred black.

YUMI
No one's ever lasted past Phase Three.

REI
She hasn't. She's somewhere else entirely.

Beat.

YUMI
She called the mirror. It cracked back.

REI
So what do we do?

YUMI
We give her what she wants.

Rei raises an eyebrow.

REI
Which is?

YUMI
To be seen.

CUT TO:

INT. AKIRA'S ROOM - LATER

The same room. Same silence. But the air, heavier now. Like breath held in a vault.

Akira sits cross-legged on the floor. She stares at a photo of her sister and her, burned at the edges. Still warm.

A soft KNOCK.

She doesn’t answer.

The door opens.

Yumi steps in, this time without a file. Without a clipboard. Just her.

Akira looks up.

YUMI
You said it wasn’t you. In the mirror.

AKIRA
It smiled.

YUMI
Then who was it?

Akira stands. Slowly. Her voice leveled, grounded, but stripped of pretense.

AKIRA
Someone I’ll have to become.

Yumi crosses the room.

They stand face to face. Breath syncing.

YUMI
When I went through... I thought I was still me. Until I laughed and it didn’t sound like mine.

Akira looks into her.

AKIRA
Is this your laugh now?

Yumi leans in. Barely a breath between them.

YUMI
I don’t laugh anymore.

A moment. The air hums between their bodies. Charged.

AKIRA
Then let’s remember how.

The lights dim.

CUT TO:

INT. TRANSFER CHAMBER - NIGHT

Clinical. Ritualistic. A circular room lined with velvet-black soundproofing. Cameras hidden behind mirrored domes. The hum of surveillance like breath on glass.

Akira stands alone in the center.

Her posture, straight, defiant. She wears the transfer whites, sterile, sleeveless. Her scar exposed.

A circular track of LIGHT ignites beneath her feet, like a halo inverted.

REI (O.S.)
Stand by.

A door HISS-OPENS. Yumi enters. Composed, eyes unreadable. She carries a polished metal briefcase.

AKIRA
Another gift?

YUMI
A final confirmation.

She opens the case. Inside, a slim surgical device. And a SYRINGE. Black fluid. Viscous. Metallic.

AKIRA
No.

YUMI
You agreed. Full conversion.

AKIRA
(to herself)
I didn’t understand the terms.

Yumi steps closer. Holds the syringe gently, like it’s sacred.

YUMI
You disappear so you may be remade.

AKIRA
(softly)
And what do I become?

YUMI
Someone we can trust.

A beat.

AKIRA
Then you made a mistake.

Without warning, Akira knocks the case aside. The syringe shatters. The black liquid hisses against the floor, burning faint smoke.

ALARMS do NOT sound. The system does not react.

But Yumi’s breath hitches, the first time we’ve seen her lose poise.

YUMI
Do you think this isn’t part of the script?

AKIRA
Then rewrite it.

Akira turns, walks toward the sealed door. It doesn’t open.

She presses her hand against it. Waits.

YUMI
You’re already inside.

Akira doesn’t look back.

AKIRA
Then you should’ve locked the walls tighter.

Her reflection appears in the mirrored dome above. For a moment, the glyph 黒神 flickers across the surface, as if projected from beneath her skin.

Yumi sees it.

For the first time, true fear.

CUT TO:

INT. SERVER NODE ROOM - SAME

A rack of humming machines. Lights pulse in sync. Wires like arteries.

Rei watches the feed. A technician trembles beside him.

TECHNICIAN
She wasn't tagged. Not fully.

REI
(frozen)
Then we lost her the moment she signed.

TECHNICIAN
Sir... the algorithm's rewriting itself.

On-screen, Akira's digital profile begins to corrupt. Names vanish. Files erase. Her projected occupation blinks out.

The tag: SUBJECT STATUS: UNDEFINED.

REI
Get me Yumi. Now.

CUT TO:

INT. TRANSFER CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS

Yumi still stands in the middle of the room.

Akira is gone.

Only the shattered case remains. And the burned symbol etched faintly into the floor.

Yumi bends. Touches the ashes.

Her whisper, not to anyone present.

YUMI
Kurokami...

CUT TO:

INT. TRANSFER OBSERVATION ROOM - NIGHT

Sterile. Circular. No corners to hide in. The walls hum — not with electricity, but memory. Cold metal and warm breath.

Yumi stands behind a two-way mirror. Observing.

On the other side, Akira Kneels on the floor. Eyes closed. Breathing slowly. Her palms are flat to the tile, as if feeling for something buried beneath.

She speaks without opening her eyes:

AKIRA
It’s quieter when you’re here.

Yumi doesn’t move.

AKIRA (CONT’D)
Not quiet. Just... less screaming.

Yumi steps into the room.

The door closes behind her like a vault.

YUMI
You shouldn’t be unsupervised.

AKIRA
I’m always supervised.

Akira finally opens her eyes. Looks up.

AKIRA (CONT’D)
Just not always seen.

A beat. Yumi kneels across from her.

Too close. Not close enough.

Their knees nearly touch.

YUMI
What do you think this place is?

AKIRA
A mirror.

YUMI
Of what?

AKIRA
What you want me to be.

Yumi swallows. Carefully.

YUMI
That’s not true.

AKIRA
Isn’t it?

Akira reaches forward. Fingertips almost brushing Yumi’s. Static in the space between them.

AKIRA (CONT’D)
You knew my sister, didn’t you?

Yumi doesn’t answer.

AKIRA (CONT’D)
Did you erase her... or did you love her first?

Yumi blinks, like a shudder through the spine.

YUMI
I don’t remember.

AKIRA
Liar.

Yumi’s hand trembles. Just slightly. She covers it with the other.

YUMI
You were never supposed to wake up like this.

Akira studies her. Something unspoken. Something broken.

AKIRA
Then close your eyes.

Yumi leans in, breath shallow, and for one charged second, it feels like she might. Like she might collapse into whatever this is.

But she doesn’t.

Instead, she stands.

Voice gone clinical.

YUMI
Protocol resumes at 0600.

She turns to leave.

Akira stays kneeling. But her voice follows, soft, searing.

AKIRA
You felt her die. Didn’t you?

Yumi freezes. Doesn’t turn around.

AKIRA (CONT’D)
I think that’s why you keep watching me.

YUMI
(soft)
You want to see if the end looks the same.

The door hisses open.

Yumi exits.

Akira lowers her head. For a moment, the hum stops.

CUT TO:

INT. LAUNDRY CORRIDOR - NIGHT

Steam lingers. White sheets ripple faintly on suspended wires — institutional, bloodless.

AKIRA walks slowly, cradling her arms. Barefoot. Disoriented. The overhead hum drones like breath held too long.

She stops.

At the far end of the corridor a silhouette. Small. Slight. Back turned. Dressed in the same facility robe.

AKIRA
(soft, involuntary)
Nami...?

The silhouette tilts its head. Slowly. Unnaturally. Not turning.

Akira steps forward. The lights BUZZ.

She reaches out, fingers trembling just above the fabric of a hanging sheet.

The sheet ripples and the silhouette is gone.

Just another subject, folding laundry in silence.

But something LINGERS in the frame. A memory misfiled.

INT. SHOWER ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

Akira, alone now. Steam swallowing her reflection.

She stares at the mirror.

And there, just behind her, in the fogged glass, two faint outlines.

SISTERS. Holding hands.

Then the condensation drips. And she's alone again.

INT. SHOWER ROOM - NIGHT

Steam hisses.

The last drops slide from Akira's skin. She stands, motionless. Damp hair clinging to her back. The mirror — still fogged — gives no reflection. Or maybe too many.

CUT TO:

INT. MEDICAL CORRIDOR - NIGHT

Bare feet. Wet against tile. Akira walks the corridor alone, wrapped in a thin facility robe.

The LIGHTS above her BUZZ, then FLUTTER, strobing for a half-second before stabilizing.

A pair of NURSES pass her. They speak in hushed Japanese. One avoids eye contact. The other stares too long, lips twitching like she wants to speak... or confess.

Akira turns a corner.

INT. MEAL DISTRIBUTION BAY - MOMENTS LATER

A line of subjects. Identical robes. Plastic trays. Robotic efficiency.

Akira steps forward. The SERVER, male, young, pauses before handing her the tray.

Her portion is different.

No rice.

A cup of thick, grey protein slurry. No utensils.

The SERVER glances at the screen behind the counter. Something flashes, RED STATUS - PENDING OBSERVATION.

Akira takes the tray. No reaction. But the subjects behind her begin whispering.

INT. DINING HALL - MOMENTS LATER

Low drone of fluorescent light. Rows of tables. Structured silence.

Akira sits at the edge.

Far from the others.

Across the room, a GROUP OF SUBJECTS freeze mid-bite when they see her. One of them, older, eyes sunken, slowly stands.

SUBJECT
(softly, in awe)
Kurokami...

The others quickly shush him.

He sits. Trembling.

Akira doesn’t move. Her reflection in the spoon WARPED, the metal curves her face into something unfamiliar.

INT. DORM HALL - LATER

She walks past her old room. The door now reads, OCCUPIED. She’s been reassigned.

INT. NEW DORM - NIGHT

Smaller. No window. Mirror is bolted to the wall, but misaligned.

As she moves, her reflection doesn’t sync. A breath too slow.

Akira stands perfectly still.

Then, her reflection SMILES.

But she hasn’t.

She blinks.

The smile is gone.

CUT TO:

INT. MONITORING HUB - SAME TIME

Yumi watches the feed.

Multiple angles of Akira. Each slightly out of sync. Her data scrolls beneath: ELEVATED THETA WAVES. ANOMALOUS ACTIVITY. IDENTITY VARIANCE FLAGGED.

Rei enters behind her.

REI
You need to detach.

YUMI
She shouldn't be responding this quickly.

REI
Then she's not responding.

YUMI
She's adapting.

REI
That's not in the script.

They watch as Akira slowly lies down on the sterile bed. Arms folded across her chest. Eyes wide open.

REI (CONT'D)
(cont'd)
We'll write her a new one.

CUT TO:

INT. CORRIDOR - NIGHT

A long, fluorescent-lit hallway. The floor waxed to sterility. Steam clings to Akira's damp skin as she walks barefoot, her robe clinging to her shoulders like wet paper.

She passes glass doors.

Inside each room, subjects. Some sleep. Some stare. One weeps into her hands, silently. No one looks up.

But as Akira passes, their breath syncs. As if a new current has entered the bloodstream of the building.

She stops.

INT. ARCHIVE NOOK - NIGHT

Not on any map. A tucked-away cubicle of forgotten files. Fluorescent lighting flickers above dusty shelves.

Akira enters.

A single SUBJECT (19, androgynous, gaunt) is kneeling. Restocking boxes. A routine repeated too many times.

Akira watches them work. Silently.

SUBJECT
(quiet)
This is restricted.

AKIRA
Then why are you here?

The Subject doesn't answer. Doesn’t look up.

Akira crosses slowly. Reaches for a black folder marked: REQUEST: TERMINATION - SUBJECT CLASS D - UNRESOLVED

SUBJECT
(distant)
You shouldn’t touch that.

Akira opens it anyway.

Redacted text. Blurred images. A name that isn’t hers, but feels like it. Blood seeps through a copied photo. Her own eyes, almost.

She places a hand on the page. Holds it there.

The Subject turns.

Their eyes meet.

A flicker.

RECOGNITION. Not memory. Something older. Primal.

SUBJECT (CONT’D)
(faltering)
You’re not supposed to be here yet.

AKIRA
But I am.

The Subject starts to say something else, then flinches. Looks past her.

Akira turns.

A camera above them WHIRS.

Red light blinking. Watching.

She closes the folder.

The Subject bows their head. Shame? Prayer?

SUBJECT
They'll come now.

AKIRA
Let them.

She walks out, unhurried.

The camera follows.

INT. SANITIZATION STATION - NIGHT

Akira steps into the white chamber. Places her palms to the scanner. It BEEPS.

Nothing happens.

She does it again.

This time, the scanner SPARKS, then goes dark.

Akira stares at her hands.

CLOSE ON- Her fingers. Trembling slightly. Skin beginning to blister, faintly, chemically, like the building is rejecting her.

CUT TO:

INT. MONITORING BAY - SAME

Rei stands over a console.

TECHNICIAN
She touched a locked file.

REI
(quiet)
Was it hers?

TECHNICIAN
Not exactly. But... close enough.

Yumi enters. Sees the footage.

On the screen, Akira. Silent. Still.

REI
She's deviating.

YUMI
No.
(beat)
She's remembering.

Off the silence-

SMASH CUT TO:

INT. AKIRA'S ROOM - NIGHT

Akira sits on the bed. Unmoving. But her reflection in the one-way glass doesn't match.

The reflection BREATHES. Slightly out of sync.

Her eyes don't blink. But the image does.

A fracture.

CUT TO:

INT. PSYCHOLOGICAL OBSERVATION CHAMBER - NIGHT

Clinical white. But not sterile. There's something indulgent in the silence. Like a room made for confessions that never leave the floor.

A table. Two chairs. A sensor wand. Electrodes. A one-way mirror.

Yumi stands by the table. Professional. Composed. Almost detached, but not quite.

Akira enters in silence. Barefoot. Her robe clings in places it shouldn't. Damp from the shower, or the memory of it.

YUMI
Take a seat.

Akira doesn't obey. She looks around instead, eyes slow, measuring.

AKIRA
Will I be shocked if I lie?

Yumi doesn’t answer.

AKIRA (CONT’D)
No... that would be too obvious.

Yumi gestures. Akira sits.

The wand HUMS quietly as Yumi passes it over Akira’s body, neck, chest, wrists. Data flickers across the screen beside her. Biological readings. Emotion proxies. All red.

YUMI
Try to keep your thoughts neutral.

AKIRA
Try to stop watching me when I sleep.

Yumi freezes. Just for a beat.

YUMI
Begin sequence one.

A pattern appears on the wall screen. Pulsing. Hypnotic.

Yumi sits across from her.

AKIRA
Why don’t you ever ask me real questions?

YUMI
This is not about your answers.

AKIRA
Then what is it about?

YUMI
Control.

Akira leans forward.

AKIRA
Yours... or mine?

Yumi doesn’t blink.

Akira places her palms on the table. Slowly spreads her fingers. Like an offering.

The hum in the room deepens.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
If I'm just a subject... why are your hands shaking?

Yumi's hand curls into a fist.

Akira rises. Walks around behind Yumi. Close. Too close.

She leans down, her breath against Yumi's neck.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
Tell me what you did with her.

Yumi's breath catches. She doesn't turn.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
You remember her. I see it. Right now. In your skin.

Beat. Yumi turns suddenly, facing her, almost colliding. Inches apart.

YUMI
You don't get to ask me questions.

AKIRA
Then punish me.

A brutal silence.

Yumi reaches out, grabs Akira's wrist. Too hard. Her voice drops, raw.

YUMI
You think this is power?

AKIRA
No. This is surrender.

Beat.

Yumi's eyes, wild. Something between panic and desire.

She kisses her.

But it's not release. It's a shattering.

Too hard. Too honest.

Then- Yumi rips herself away. Breath ragged. Looks toward the mirror.

YUMI
Terminate sequence.

Nothing happens.

YUMI (CONT'D)
I said terminate—

The door opens.

Rei stands there. Calm. Watching. He saw everything.

Akira turns. Composed. Not ashamed. Her gaze meets Rei's like a challenge.

Yumi can't look at either of them.

REI
Yumi. With me.

Yumi follows. Shaken. Ruined.

Akira remains behind. Alone.

The hum of the sensors fades.

The only sound left... is her breathing.

CUT TO:

INT. HALLWAY OUTSIDE OBSERVATION CHAMBER - MOMENTS LATER

Rei walks. Yumi follows.

REI
That was not protocol.

Yumi doesn't respond.

REI (CONT'D)
Do you know what she is yet?

YUMI
(quiet)
Yes.

Rei stops. Turns.

REI
Then act like it.

CUT TO:

INT. OBSERVATION CHAMBER - SAME

Akira sits again. Alone. But not broken.

She touches her lips. Smiles.

Not victory. Recognition.

CUT TO:

INT. FILE STORAGE - NIGHT

Cold.

Aisles of locked cabinets. Metal drawers labeled in Kanji and barcode. Fluorescent lights flicker with mechanical indifference. No cameras visible.

Akira enters.

Her hospital robe clings damply to her back. She walks as if she belongs here, though she doesn't.

Footsteps echo.

She passes through rows of classified memory. The place smells of toner, rust, and something sweeter, like old blood scrubbed with lemon.

She stops.

A flicker, not in the lights, but on a terminal screen.

MONITOR (V.O.)
Authentication Failed. Clearance Required.

She tilts her head.

Something's wrong with the terminal. A soft loop glitch a visual stutter in the top-right corner.

Akira steps closer. Touches a key.

The screen wavers. Then shifts.

A file list, names partially redacted, most trailing off into corrupted script.

One entry doesn't blink. SUBJECT FILE - NOMURA, N.

Akira freezes.

She presses another key. ACCESS DENIED.

But the glitch catches again. The screen flickers and for a single frame, just long enough to wound, A PHOTOGRAPH. Two girls. Young. Identical eyes. One slightly older. One bruised.

Then— data fractures. The screen pixelates. Folders re-scramble.

Just before the image collapses entirely, a single glyph pulses 黒神, then black.

Akira breathes. Not shocked. Not scared. Not yet. Just seen.

Behind her, a faint sound, metal drawer sliding closed. She turns, no one there.

She looks back. The monitor is dead.

Only her reflection remains, caught in the dark glass. But her eyes aren't hers. Not anymore.

CUT TO:

INT. CORRIDOR - NIGHT

Akira walks back into light.

The hallway lights don't flicker. But the hum is louder now. Hungrier.

She doesn't look back.

CUT TO:

INT. LEVEL B6 - SERVICE ELEVATOR - NIGHT

A thumbprint scanner glows blue. Akira stares at it.

She holds her breath. Places her finger.

The scanner pauses. Then- ACCESS GRANTED.

The elevator shudders, then sinks.

INT. LEVEL B7 - MAINTENANCE HALLWAY - NIGHT

Dim. Abandoned. Not forbidden, forgotten.

Rust streaks the corners of elegance. Mold on porcelain. The machine’s bowels.

She moves soundlessly. Until she stops.

A door marked, MEMORY INDEX / PHASED.

Painted-over. Scratched open again.

She pushes.

INT. MEMORY INDEX - NIGHT

Rows of obsolete data terminals hum faintly. Like dying lungs.

The air is wet here. Decay in digital form.

She walks between the aisles. A graveyard of forgotten lives.

One monitor flickers on, without touch.

A FACE. Smudged. Flickering. Her face, but younger. Pale. Wide-eyed.

AKIRA
(softly)
No...

The screen distorts, then stabilizes.

DATA STREAM: Subject 0-KK / 黒神 / Kurokami. Phase 2: Reinstatement Failure. Emotion Lock: Breach. Memory Residue: Active.

She reaches out. The image glitches again and another face overlays hers. Sickly. Hair shorn. Lips sewn.

Subject 0-KK convulses on the feed. The camera lingers far too long.

Then- a sound. FOOTSTEPS. Not hers.

She kills the screen. Ducks behind the console.

Through a crack between consoles, she sees a figure enter, not security.

Another woman. Frail. Silent. Eyes gone glassy.

A faint moan. Like a song half-remembered.

Akira watches. The woman walks to the screen. Touches it.

It flashes, shows Akira again.

But the woman doesn’t flinch.

She speaks, low.

WOMAN
(softly)
Did you bring me back again...?

Akira rises. Slowly. Cautiously.

AKIRA
Do you know me?

The woman turns.

WOMAN
I know the shape of your silence.

She smiles, too wide.

Behind her, the screen blinks, SYSTEM ALERT: PRESENCE BREACH.

The room’s lights shift red.

Akira backs away- but the woman’s smile fades to something... sorrowful.

WOMAN (CONT’D)
They can’t kill you yet. Not until they understand why you’re still here.

Her eyes twitch. As if listening to something Akira cannot hear.

WOMAN (CONT’D)
Run.

Akira bolts.

INT. SERVICE CORRIDOR - NIGHT

Alarm lights now strobe softly, not screaming, but pulsing.

The system isn’t warning her.

It’s watching.

INT. ELEVATOR SHAFT - NIGHT

She doesn’t wait for the elevator.

She climbs.

Bare hands. Metal rungs. Every breath a warning.

INT. HER ROOM - NIGHT

Akira bursts inside. Shuts the door. Leans against it.

Breath ragged. But not broken.

In her palm, a stolen shard of circuitry. Still warm.

From the failed girl. Or the girl who failed to vanish.

Either way, Akira now carries proof.

CUT TO:

INT. BOARDING LIFT - NIGHT

Yumi stands alone. Elevator walls of black glass reflect her in pieces, ractured, refracted.

A CHIME.

The doors slide open.

INT. UPPER ADMINISTRATION - LEVEL ZERO - CONTINUOUS

Minimal. Opulent. The air smells like old lacquer and quiet violence.

She walks. Her heels echo too loud.

INT. THE VAULTED COUNCIL ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

Circular. No windows. Just walls of obsidian stone and three slightly elevated chairs, empty.

One figure stands in the center, Rei. Sharp-suited. Emotionless. Ccurated by committee.

YUMI
You summoned me.

REI
(pleasant)
I did.

He gestures. She walks forward. Slowly.

REI (CONT'D)
Do you know the difference between privacy and discretion, Yumi?

YUMI
One's an illusion. The other's a privilege.

REI
(smiling thinly)
Good girl.

He steps closer. A breath too close. Never touches her. Yet the threat hums between molecules.

REI (CONT'D)
You've been watched. Not for impropriety. For deviation.

YUMI
Protocol has not been broken.

REI
Doesn't need to be. Not if the story shifts. Not if your face reads differently… to the wrong eyes.

He moves behind her. A pause. A click.

A mirror wall flickers on. Surveillance feeds, each one playing slightly out of sync.

We see: Yumi kneeling in front of Akira. Yumi's hand, trembling, then resting against her own thigh. The sound of Yumi's breath, too fast.

REI (CONT'D)
There is no such thing as off-record.
(leans in)
Only off-script.

Yumi stares at the feed. Her shame weaponized. Her image corrupted.

REI (CONT'D)
You know what happens when the Mukurokai suspects… infection.

He lifts something small and silver from his pocket.

A SCALPEL.

YUMI
(flat)
Are you going to cut me?

REI
Only if you keep bleeding into the work.

A beat.

YUMI
She's not like the others.

REI
And that frightens you… or excites you?

Yumi doesn't answer. Her silence says too much.

REI (CONT'D)
You let one remember before. I was there. We had to burn an entire wing.

YUMI
This one's different.

REI
They all are. Until they're not.

He places the scalpel in her hand. The blade rests against her palm.

REI (CONT'D)
Choose your loyalty, Yumi. Or we'll choose for you.

She stares down at it.

Doesn't flinch.

Doesn't bleed.

REI (CONT'D)
You may go.

INT. CORRIDOR - MOMENTS LATER

Yumi walks out.

The scalpel still in her hand.

She doesn’t look back.

CUT TO:

INT. SECURITY FEED — UNKNOWN LOCATION

A figure watches the footage.

Not Rei. Not anyone we’ve seen before.

Face in shadow. Fingernail tapping glass.

MONITOR: Freeze frame of Akira’s face.

Then a second monitor: Akira’s face, as a child. Same eyes. Same defiance.

The figure leans forward.

We hear the hum.

Then— a whisper.

VOICE (O.S.)
Kurokami…

CUT TO:

INT. DORMITORY HALL - NIGHT

Muted. Institutional beige.

Akira moves slowly, barefoot, silent. The air smells faintly of antiseptic and warm linen.

A subject, the one who flinched at her touch, s gone.

Her bed is stripped. The folded robe rests on the mattress like a body-shaped apology.

No personal items. No name tag. Not even a trace of breath left behind.

Akira steps closer.

INT. DORMITORY HALL - CONTINUOUS

She walks the line of identical rooms. A ghost through a gallery of the living.

She turns a corner.

A smear. Something dark, wiped. Almost clean.

She kneels.

The floor glistens faintly.

A faint scent. Metal. Bleach.

From around the corner, VOICES. Low. Controlled. Footsteps.

A SECURITY TEAM. Two men. One woman. No insignia. No names.

They pass her. Not fast. Not slow. Not looking.

No one speaks.

No one sees her.

INT. COMMON AREA - MOMENTS LATER

Akira sits alone. Center of the room. Nothing in her hands.

Around her, others speak in whispers. Fold laundry. Stare blankly at muted television.

She watches them.

But they do not look back.

INT. DORMITORY - RETURN

Akira returns to the empty bed.

She reaches out.

Touches the folded robe.

Her fingers curl. Not to hold, to memorize.

The grain of the fabric. The shape of the collar. The seam like a throat.

She closes her eyes.

FLASH CUT:

A wall of mirrors. Each shows her reflection slightly differently.

In one, the missing subject stares back.

In another, her sister.

In another, no one.

BACK-

Akira stands.

She does not cry.

She does not speak.

She walks away. And takes the robe with her.

CUT TO:

INT. MONITORING BAY - SAME

A camera watches her leave the room.

The screen doesn’t log her name.

Just one word, VARIANT.

CUT TO:

INT. INTERROGATION SUITE - NOCTURNE - DAY

Sterile. Seamless. The kind of white that erases depth.

Akira sits at a metal table. Her posture is too perfect, the stillness of prey deciding whether to strike or surrender.

Across from her, an unmarked file.

The door hisses.

Yumi enters, carrying a black leather folder. No clipboard. No cuffs. Just that calm, dangerous poise.

YUMI
This won’t take long.

AKIRA
It never does. Until it never ends.

Yumi doesn’t respond. She sits. Opens the folder. Slides a single page across the table.

It’s printed on thick, high-gauge paper. Governmental. Judicial.

Beneath dense redacted blocks and legalese: SIGNATURE: KUROKAMI, AKIRA.

Akira doesn’t move.

YUMI
You signed this the night of your intake.

AKIRA
No, I didn’t.

YUMI
It’s your name.

AKIRA
That’s not the same thing.

Yumi watches her. Something stirs beneath the surface.

AKIRA (CONT’D)
I remember that night. I remember being blindfolded. Strapped down. I remember the needle. But not this.

YUMI
You don’t remember a lot of things.

Akira leans forward. Her breath fogs the glass of water Yumi didn’t offer.

AKIRA
That’s by design, isn’t it?

YUMI
Do you deny volunteering?

AKIRA
Do you?

The silence sharpens. A mutual accusation neither of them fully understands.

Yumi reaches into the folder again. Pulls out a recording chip- thin, translucent, with a biometric seal. She places it next to the contract.

YUMI
If you'd like to challenge your memory, you can authorize the playback.

AKIRA
And watch a version of me ask for this?

YUMI
We don't forge consent. We record it.

AKIRA
No. You perform it.

Beat.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
Like a script. Like a death sentence no one has to sign if the actor smiles.

Yumi looks down.

YUMI
You were lucid. Articulate. You said you wanted to disappear.

AKIRA
I said I wanted out.

YUMI
Same thing here.

Akira touches the edge of the paper.

AKIRA
Is it?

Yumi doesn't answer. She stands. Begins to gather the items.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
If I signed it… then revoke it.

YUMI
You can't revoke absolution.

Yumi hesitates, just long enough to betray something. Then exits.

Akira is left with the ghost of her own handwriting.

CLOSE ON THE CONTRACT- The signature flickers. For a single frame, it reads, NAMIKO.

CUT TO:

INT. MEMORY CHAMBER - NIGHT

Dark. Hushed. A room built for illusion.

Holographic projectors cast a low fog, suspended like incense smoke. At its center, AKIRA stands still, the only motion in the space her slow inhale.

A faint pulse in the air. The machine breathing.

A voice, clinical, smooth, begins playback.

SYSTEM (V.O.)
Subject 33. Initiation memory.
Timestamp redacted.

The fog solidifies.

A memory forms. A YOUNGER AKIRA. Smiling. Willing.

She stands at the threshold of Nocturne. Not dragged. Not drugged.

Invited.

Yumi is there too. Younger. Softer. She touches Akira's hand, not with force, but familiarity.

YUMI (MEMORY)
You understand what this means.

AKIRA (MEMORY)
I want to be clean.

Real Akira flinches. Just barely. Her own smile, unfamiliar, grotesque, lingers in front of her.

SYSTEM (V.O.)
Consent logged. Processing entry.

In the projected memory, Akira steps forward. Fades into light.

STRANGER (O.S.)
She begged us.

The voice is not the system. It cuts through the falseness like bone through silk.

STRANGER (O.S.) (CONT'D)
She wanted this. Just like the others.

The image glitches. Akira's face flickers, now hers, now someone else's... A dozen smiling versions. The Yumi in the memory turns away, face unreadable.

AKIRA
I never said that.

The fog begins to ripple. Distort. The system fights back.

SYSTEM (V.O.)
Please remain calm. Deviation will be recorded.

AKIRA (LOW)
You made this.

She reaches into the holographic projection.

Her hand sinks through herself. Through the memory. Through the lie.

The room flashes.

All images burn white, then collapse.

INT. MEMORY CHAMBER - SECONDS LATER

Only Akira remains.

A single word is burned across the projector screen, KUROKAMI.

She breathes. Once. Then exits into silence.

CUT TO:

INT. SURVEILLANCE ROOM - SAME

Rei watches the playback. Expression unreadable.

REI
She's starting to dream in reverse.

Behind him, a chair creaks.

But the superior presence never speaks.

Only watches.

CUT TO:

INT. NOCTURNE - HALLWAY OUTSIDE ADMIN WING - NIGHT

Clinical silence. Air recycled to sterility. Yumi walks fast, not running, but her heels echo like gunshots. She reaches for her keycard.

It doesn't beep.

She swipes again. Nothing. A red light pulses. Watching.

YUMI
(quietly)
No. Not now.

A distant hum, like something deep in the walls, shifts tone.

Yumi exhales, turns and another door down the hall opens for her without a sound.

INT. NOCTURNE - MONITORING BAY - NIGHT

Banks of screens. Surveillance feeds in clinical monochrome. Footage scrolls endlessly. Subjects washing. Sleeping. Obeying.

Yumi approaches a terminal. Types. A login prompt flickers. She logs in.

Multiple feeds populate the screen. She scrolls back — to her last session with Akira.

STATIC.

She tries again. Another angle. More static.

Her fingers tremble.

She tries a hidden backup. An off-grid cache only handlers should know.

This time, an image resolves, Yumi and Akira, mid-session. Frozen. Silent.

Yumi leans in.

The image glitches. Flickers.

For one frame, Yumi is alone. Talking to nothing. Reaching toward the empty chair.

And then- the screen goes black.

INT. NOCTURNE - CORPORATE OBSERVATION ROOM - NIGHT

Rei stands at the far end of the polished obsidian room. Behind him, high-backed chairs, faces unseen. The Mukurokai council, or the illusion of one.

Yumi stands opposite, posture perfect. But her pulse is visible in her throat.

REI
We don’t edit footage, do we?

YUMI
No.

REI
And we certainly don’t misfile sessions. Or redirect subject metadata.

YUMI
Of course not.

Rei steps closer. His voice drops to something silk-wrapped and serrated.

REI
You’re too good for that. Too careful.

He studies her.

REI (CONT’D)
So how do we explain... that you spent ninety-three minutes talking to an empty chair?

Yumi doesn’t answer. Her jaw clenches.

REI (CONT’D)
(softly)
You let one remember before.

A flicker in Yumi’s eyes, guilt, rage, fear. She looks down.

REI (CONT’D)
This is your warning, Yumi.

He lifts her chin with a single finger.

REI (CONT'D)
Next time, I won't speak it aloud.

Beat.

YUMI
Understood.

He steps away.

REI
Return to protocol. And Yumi...

She turns slightly. Doesn't look at him.

REI (CONT'D)
No more ghosts.

INT. ADMIN CORRIDOR - NIGHT

Yumi walks. Controlled. Expressionless.

Her keycard flickers back to green.

But she doesn't smile.

Behind her, a panel in the wall blinks red, unnoticed.

CUT TO:

INT. MEDICAL TRANSFER STATION - DAY

Fluorescent light bleeds from the ceiling. A whirring. Hushed, deliberate movement.

Akira sits in a metal chair, not bound, but unmoving. Her posture, perfect. Blank.

TWO TECHNICIANS hover near her. One inserts a clear syringe into a port on her neck. The liquid glows faintly. Too clean to be safe.

TECHNICIAN 1
Adjusting baseline. Protocol 12C.

TECHNICIAN 2
(not looking at her)
Eyes open. Say your name.

AKIRA
Akira.

The second technician nods. No expression. They wheel a small tablet into place. Data scrolls. Vitals sync.

But one waveform trembles, just slightly.

INT. NEW WING - OBSERVATION CORRIDOR - LATER

Akira walks, flanked by two silent guards. Her robe is a slightly different shade now. Off-white instead of gray.

Everything here is the same, but wrong. Subjects do not meet her eyes. A mirror reflects her… but a frame behind her is empty.

INT. NEW ROOM - NIGHT

Her new cell is smaller. Sterile. No mirror. No belongings. The walls are matte.

On the cot, a folded robe. Another subject's. Marked with a numeric ID. 1098.

Akira stares at it. Then slowly opens the collar. A data chip is sewn into the seam.

She removes it.

She knows she is not supposed to.

INT. CORRIDOR - LATER

Akira passes a communal console. The guards pause to scan her entry band.

In that fraction of distraction, she slips the chip into the input tray.

SCREEN: UPLOADING... ERROR... DATA CORRUPT.

Then- a glitch.

A flash of faces. Hers. Another’s. A moment frozen. Laughter in a garden. A child’s voice. The word, NAMIKO.

SCREEN RESETS: BLANK.

INT. COMMON ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

A YOUNG SUBJECT stares at Akira from across the room. Not fear. Recognition.

SUBJECT
(whispers)
You're her.

Akira doesn't blink.

AKIRA
Who?

The subject turns. Fades into the flow of bodies.

INT. BACK HALLWAY - NIGHT

Yumi stands alone. Watching security footage.

On one feed, static. On another, Akira walking where she shouldn't be.

VOICE (O.S.)
Correction begins with permission.

She turns. Rei stands in the shadows.

REI
You gave her yours.

YUMI
I follow procedure.

REI
No. You follow her.

She doesn't answer. Her hands clench.

REI (CONT'D)
She's stolen something. And she knew it would cost another.

Yumi looks down, silent.

REI (CONT'D)
Now ask yourself, is that survival? Or belief?

He walks away.

INT. AKIRA'S NEW CELL - NIGHT

Akira sits alone on the cot. She holds the robe, not as comfort. As proof.

She presses her forehead to it.

Not crying.

Remembering.

CUT TO:

INT. TRANSIT CORRIDOR - NIGHT

Cold white lights buzz overhead. The sound, not quite fluorescent, carries a heartbeat rhythm, wrong and mechanical. A corridor too clean. Too silent.

Akira walks alone, her slippers catching on the matte flooring, too soft to echo. Her eyes linger on each passing security panel, each air vent, each surveillance dome.

Something is missing.

Ahead, the sharp HISS of a mechanized door.

She slows.

A GURNEY is wheeled across the intersection at the end of the corridor. Fast, clinical.

ON THE GURNEY, a woman. Drugged. Pale. Lips trembling.

Akira steps forward, a sudden compulsion.

Then— the woman turns her head.

And she looks exactly like Akira.

A beat too long. Then she's gone, swept around the corner.

Akira rushes forward.

INT. INTERSECTION - CONTINUOUS

Nothing. Empty hallway. No sound of wheels.

No echoes.

Akira turns. Her breath clouds the air, though it's not cold.

Behind her, a WHISPER.

SUBJECT 47 (O.S.)
(soft, garbled)
You’re not the first mistake.

She spins. No one.

But, down low, a maintenance hatch is half-open. Barely visible.

A red LED blinks inside.

INT. MAINTENANCE PASSAGE - LATER

Akira crawls through.

The walls close around her, ribbed tubing, exposed metal. It feels like being swallowed.

Inside, hidden monitors play black-and-white footage.

Silence.

On one screen, a younger Akira. Laughing.

On another. The Subject from earlier. Shaved head. Silent scream. Restrained.

Overlay text reads, SUBJECT 47: DEACTIVATED / ARCHIVED / ERROR.

Her face glitches. Flickers. Becomes Akira’s. Becomes someone else’s. Then back.

Akira reaches forward. The screen cuts to BLACK.

A final line blinks, INITIATE KUROKAMI CONTAINMENT.

Akira stares at the word.

It doesn't mean fear. It means confirmation.

She whispers it. Not as name, but as title.

AKIRA
(soft)
Kurokami.

Behind her, a door she didn’t see opens.

WARM LIGHT spills in.

FOOTSTEPS approach.

Not a guard.

Bare feet.

CUT TO:

INT. SURVEILLANCE NODE 3 - NIGHT

A sterile room lit only by the static glow of wall-sized monitors. Grainy feeds play in sync, dozens of subjects performing routines. Calm. Controlled.

Until- the footage begins to DESYNC. A half-second delay. Then a flicker. Then full dissonance.

INSERT: SCREEN 12B. Subject 33 (Akira). She walks a corridor. Stops. Looks up, directly at the camera.

The same feed repeats on SCREEN 12C. And 12D.

Three timelines. Three slightly different movements.

ON MONITOR. In one version, Akira smiles. In another, she bleeds. In the third, she VANISHES completely.

INT. CORRIDOR - SAME

Akira walks. Dazed. Slower than usual. The air feels thick. Whispers ahead. A cough.

SUBJECT 47 (the glitch-double from earlier), stands near the wall. Pale. Watching.

SUBJECT 47
(softly)
Akira?

Akira stops.

AKIRA
That’s not my name.

SUBJECT 47
But it was.

The whisper feels forbidden. Like a curse in a cathedral.

A SECURITY GUARD appears at the end of the hall, but doesn’t approach. Just watches. Too still.

INT. SYSTEM CONTROL - SAME

A lone TECHNICIAN stares at the screen. Types rapidly.

ON MONITOR: Subject 33 — STATUS: ACTIVE.

The field glitches. Then updates itself:STATUS: DECEASED — ARCHIVED.

The tech leans in. Confused.

He blinks.

Now it reads: STATUS: UNKNOWN.

And below it: IDENTITY MATCH ERROR.

Then- the name field updates. NAMIKO 黒神.

INT. CORRIDOR - SAME

Akira turns toward Subject 47. But she’s gone. The hallway is empty.

The lights buzz. Harsher now.

A whisper from behind her-

SUBJECT 47 (O.S.)
You remember wrong.

Akira looks up. Every camera blinks red.

And for the first time, the hallway mirror does not reflect her.

CUT TO:

INT. NOCTURNE - PSYCH EVALUATION SUITE - NIGHT

A ROOM DESIGNED TO REVEAL TRUTH, clinical, immaculate, but too symmetrical. Mirrors line the walls. No camera is visible, yet everything is seen.

Yumi stands alone. No makeup. No lab coat. No mask. Just her and the terminal.

INSERT — THE TERMINAL SCREEN: “Experimental Recall Protocol - WARNING: Unstable Cognitive Loop Risk.”

Yumi's finger hovers. Then- clicks.

The room goes dark.

SOFT HUM. Then FLASH

— INDUCTION ROOM - MEMORY

A girl. YOUNGER AKIRA. Fragile. Stripped. Smiling.

YUMI (O.S.)
She begged us.

— OBSERVATION SUITE - MEMORY

Akira screaming. Restrained. Tubes threading her skin.

REI (O.S.)
We offered her peace. She chose pain.

BACK-

Yumi JERKS in the chair. GASPING.

Her nose bleeds. She wipes it. Smears it against her white blouse. Doesn’t notice. Or doesn’t care.

She leans back.

ON SCREEN, A SLOW GLITCH forms. Her own face appears… but it’s Akira’s expression.

FEMALE SUBJECT (V.O.)
(whisper, overlapping)
You didn’t stop it. You watched.

Yumi closes her eyes. A tear. Then another.

She opens a drawer. Inside, her MASTER KEYCARD. And next to it, a single dose syringe, blue-tinted.

She touches both. Doesn’t choose yet.

BEHIND HER, A REFLECTION IN THE GLASS.

Akira. Not physically there. But there.

AKIRA (V.O.)
(low, calm)
They erased you too, didn’t they?

Yumi turns. No one.

She looks back to the screen.

FOOTAGE NOW. Akira, from earlier that day. Alone. Walking. But, the date stamp reads THREE YEARS AGO.

YUMI
(whispers)
That's impossible.

Her hands tremble. She picks up the syringe. Pauses.

Then- opens the terminal again. Begins typing.

ON SCREEN: "Override: Subject Profile - Kurokami/Access Level: Full."

REI (V.O.)
You're not here to feel, Yumi.

YUMI
I know.

Beat. Then she looks directly into the glass. Into herself.

YUMI (CONT'D)
But I remember now.

BLACK.

A SOUND.

A distorted child's laugh, processed through static.

CUT TO:

INT. CORRECTION CHAMBER - NIGHT

Silence.

Not absence, but a wound where sound should be.

White walls. Surgical lighting. A place built to erase.

Akira lies supine, wrists and ankles gently strapped. Not restrained. Displayed. Her eyes: wide open.

A READER DEVICE scans her iris. Fails. BEEP.

SCIENTIST (O.S.)
Subject unregistered. Begin manual override.

MONITORS glitch. Feed stutters. Her profile appears, then blinks away.

Her face replaced by: DATA CORRUPTED. NAMIKO. ACCESS DENIED.

Akira doesn’t blink. Doesn’t breathe wrong.

One TECHNICIAN trembles. The other injects a clear fluid into her neck. It hits. Hard.

FLASH:

- A girl, Namiko, smiling in a mirror that reflects someone else.

- Yumi, younger, whispering: "We chose her because she wanted it."

- A BLACK MASK lowered over Akira’s face.

INT. CORRECTION OBSERVATION DECK - CONTINUOUS

Yumi watches behind glass. Her hands are balled white.

Rei stands beside her. Unblinking.

REI
If she forgets herself… she returns to us. If she remembers —

YUMI
She doesn’t come back.

REI
She was never meant to.

INT. CORRECTION CHAMBER - SAME

The lights dim. Another injection prepped.

Then, the hum shifts. A frequency no one hears, but feels.

Akira lifts her eyes. Direct. Alive.

The MONITOR next to her heart rate shorts and begins to write over itself: AKIRA = NAMIKO. SUBJECT 00. K U R O K A M I.

She smiles. The second TECH freezes.

TECHNICIAN 1
(whispers)
She’s writing back.

Akira raises her hand. The straps fall away.

INT. OBSERVATION DECK - SAME

Rei SLAMS the emergency lockdown.

REI
Seal the—

But the feed is already dead. Static.

INT. CORRECTION CHAMBER - SAME

The chamber door is open now. No one opened it.

Akira steps off the table. Bare feet. No sound.

One technician begins to sob. The other stares blankly.

Akira walks past them.

INT. DATA CORE CORRIDOR - NIGHT

An overhead CAMERA rotates. Jerks. Sparks.

The corridor lights fail, one by one, in silence.

Akira moves forward. Her reflection lags a half-second behind.

Then stops entirely.

INT. SURVEILLANCE BAY - SAME

Every monitor now blinks: 黒神 黒神 黒神. BLACK SPIRIT. BLACK GOD.

Yumi stares. Whispers:

YUMI
She’s not a subject.

Beat.

She’s remembering.

INT. CORRIDOR - NIGHT

Akira walks naked into the sterile white corridor.

She is unrecorded.

Cameras can’t track her.

Mirrors don’t reflect.

She has become something they cannot measure.

Not erasure.

Not survival.

CONTAGION.

A single frame stutters onscreen, an archival glitch.

NAMIKO + AKIRA. Hands joined. One child. One ghost.

CUT TO:

EXT. NOCTURNE - EAST WING - NIGHT

CLOSE ON. A surveillance monitor. Empty corridor. Static hums faint, uncertain. A red light flickers once. Then goes dark.

INT. NOCTURNE - LEVEL 6 HALLWAY - NIGHT

Akira steps into frame.

No camera blinks. No sensor chirps. She’s not supposed to be here and yet she is.

Her footsteps are barefoot. Silent. The corridor doesn’t react. The air feels... wrong. Not empty. Listening.

INT. ADMINISTRATIVE NEXUS - MOMENTS LATER

The halls of power. Sterile glass. Fingerprint locks. No hum of electricity. No security drone.

Akira walks past.

Every door she passes... unseals with a hiss. No badge. No clearance. No reason.

She turns her head, a mirror by the wall. Her reflection doesn’t follow.

It stutters. Delays. Then vanishes entirely.

INT. DATA CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS

Fluorescent white. Ceiling-to-floor servers blink, until she steps in.

The lights dim. One by one.

She breathes out. Like fog in winter.

A drawer slides open on its own. Inside, a folded robe. Her size. Black silk. Crimson lining. Identical to the one worn in the Ghost File.

She doesn't reach for it. Not yet.

INT. SURVEILLANCE ROOM - SIMULTANEOUS

Three OPERATORS stare at a bank of monitors.

All feeds running. All systems active. But there's a gap. A shadow in the loop.

A stretch of hallway that should be lit, is dark.

A corridor where no one walks, yet things move.

OPERATOR (WHISPERS)
Are we... missing someone?

The screen glitches. For a single frame, it reads, NAMIKO.

INT. VAULTED ARCHIVES - NIGHT

Akira stands at the heart of the labyrinth.

Shelves upon shelves of sealed memories. Digitized. Sanitized. Categorized.

She reaches out, runs a finger along the spine of a case labeled: SUBJECT: KUROKAMI.

Inside. A child's drawing. Red ink on black paper. A girl with no face.

She exhales. It sounds like a sob. But her eyes remain still.

She's not confused. She's becoming.

WHISPERS (V.O.)
You're not forgotten.

CUT TO:

INT. SUBLEVEL CORRIDOR - NOCTURNE - NIGHT

Dim. Not dark, never dark, but the kind of sterile blue where breath feels monitored.

Akira moves like shadow.

Her hand grazes the wall. Lights dim in sequence, like a whisper trailing behind her.

She stops.

A LOW-LEVEL ATTENDANT, barely older than her, head shaved, badge number 0-5-8, turns a corner carrying a tray of sedatives. He sees her.

Freezes.

Their eyes meet. Recognition. Shame.

AKIRA
(quiet)
You remember me.

He says nothing.

She steps forward. He steps back. The tray trembles in his hands.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
Say it.

ATTENDANT 058
(shaking)
I— I can't.

AKIRA
You already did.

She backs him into the wall. Not violent. Intimate. One hand over his mouth. The other presses lightly to his chest, fingers splayed over his heart.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
Say what you saw.

ATTENDANT 058
(whispers)
You… you were smiling. They had your arms bound, but you smiled. You asked for it.

Beat.

AKIRA
And?

ATTENDANT 058
They said you were born wrong. That to fix you… they had to break you.

AKIRA
Was I fixed?

He breaks. His knees buckle. He slides down the wall, tray clattering to the floor, meds rolling like marbles.

ATTENDANT 058
I—I watched. I didn’t stop it. I wanted to. I couldn’t. I couldn’t move.

Akira kneels with him.

AKIRA
You weren’t the only one who wanted it.

He looks at her. Confused. Almost aroused. Almost terrified.

She leans in. Close.

AKIRA (CONT’D)
Guilt is a kind of obedience, too.

ATTENDANT 058
I dream about it. The way you looked at me, when they—

AKIRA
Tell me.

ATTENDANT 058
You weren’t afraid. You were… choosing it. Like it meant something. Like it was yours.

Akira tilts her head. Listens. Breathes him in.

AKIRA
Then you remember the wrong thing.

She stands. Looks down at him.

The corridor lights flicker, briefly, in sync with her breath.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
Thank you.

She walks away.

Behind her, the attendant stays on the floor.

The tray of sedatives untouched. But one vial is missing.

CUT TO:

INT. FORGOTTEN CHAMBER - NIGHT

A place not on any map. Faint incense smoke coils like ghosts. Half-lit, lined with paper screens, old monitors humming with static. A room designed to be forgotten.

Akira stands center. Still, unreadable. Her reflection split across two angled mirrors, neither quite her.

A DOOR OPENS.

Yumi enters. Quietly. She's not in uniform. Bare feet. White robe. Hands trembling.

She closes the door behind her.

YUMI
(soft)
You shouldn't be here.

AKIRA
Neither should you.

A silence. It breathes.

Yumi steps forward. Her eyes glassy, not from tears, but restraint.

YUMI
They're going to find you. Erase you. Again.

Akira doesn't answer. Instead, she watches Yumi cross the threshold, barefoot on cold wood.

YUMI (CONT'D)
I remember you. From before. Not clearly. Like music behind a wall.

She stands inches away now. Her fingers twitch.

YUMI (CONT'D)
But I remember wanting you to remember me.

She reaches up, touches Akira's cheek with the back of her fingers. Gentle. Reverent. Not possessive.

AKIRA
You helped them break me.

YUMI
I watched. I documented. I rationalized.

She lowers her hand. Shame floods her.

YUMI (CONT'D)
I told myself protocol was mercy.

She undoes her robe.

YUMI (CONT'D)
I have no right to ask anything.

The robe slips, not dramatic. Not performed. A quiet surrender. She kneels.

YUMI (CONT'D)
But if part of you still lives... if she remembers me, then let me give you back what I took.

Akira kneels in front of her. They are face to face. Bare. Broken.

A long, aching pause.

Yumi leans in, not to seduce. To confess.

Their lips touch.

Not frantic. Not romantic. A press of memory. Of consent. Of need.

Akira pulls away, barely.

AKIRA
This won't save you.

YUMI
It's not to be saved.

Akira brushes her forehead against Yumi's.

AKIRA
Then remember this.

Their foreheads stay touching.

A low alarm hums somewhere far away.

INT. MONITOR ROOM - SAME

Several SCREENS show static. Then, briefly-

TWO WOMEN. Bare. Kneeling. Touching.

Then black.

NOCTURNE no longer watches. Or can't.

INT. FORGOTTEN CHAMBER - NIGHT

Yumi is crying now. Silently. Akira holds her. Not as comfort. As acknowledgment.

AKIRA (V.O.)
We remember in silence. In shame.
In skin. That's why they fear us.

CUT TO:

INT. STERILE WHITE ROOM - PRE-DAWN

Minimalist. Unforgiving. The kind of room that was never meant for sleep.

Yumi lies alone in the treatment bed. Bare shoulders. The sheet beside her, folded with exacting precision. The indentation of a body already erased.

Her fingers drift to the place where Akira had been. Still warm. Still present in the way perfume lingers in an elevator.

Her lips, faintly parted. Moist. A memory of a kiss that asked nothing but changed everything.

A soft hum stirs above her. The surveillance monitor flickers. Then static. Then nothing.

Her last session with Akira, ERASED.

Yumi blinks. The emptiness hits her. But she doesn't panic.

She smiles.

YUMI
(whisper)
She’s doing it.

CUT TO:

INT. THE ARCHIVE BELOW - NIGHT

Industrial. Subterranean. A forgotten floor not listed on any blueprint.

Dust trembles beneath humming conduits. Fluorescent panels flicker—buzzing like distant insects.

Akira enters, barefoot. Her gown barely grazes the cold tile. She isn’t cold.

She’s untouchable.

Security lights don’t register her. No red flash. No beep.

This place was never meant to be entered. Not even by the architects.

AKIRA
(to herself)
If they didn’t erase me here...
They never could.

She moves between rows of decaying servers. Towers of silent breath. Machinery older than the current regime. Older than her recorded birth.

Her fingers graze the servers, reverent, sensual. They respond.

Soft whirring. A green light blinks to life.

Akira stops. Before her- a terminal. CRT monitor. Dust-caked keys.

She sits.

Her fingers type with unnatural certainty. Lines of code scroll.

Access logs. Names. Images. Death certificates with living faces. Stamped lies.

Then— A FILE. Untitled.

Click.

A black and white photo blooms slowly on the screen.

A CHILD. Seven, maybe eight. Standing in a training corridor. Holding a compliance ribbon. Smiling.

Behind her, Yumi. Much younger. Unscarred.

Akira doesn’t blink.

AKIRA (V.O.)
I was always here.
Even before I remembered.

She prints the image. The printer groans, it hasn’t been used in years. The paper curls in her hand. Still warm.

She doesn’t cry.

She memorizes.

Her reflection flickers in the monitor. Not synced.

In it, the child still smiles. But Akira, does not.

She rises. With the photo in hand, she walks back through the server maze, as if leading ghosts.

The data banks hum louder.

Wires shiver. Lights dim.

AKIRA (V.O.) (CONT'D)
Truth isn’t power.
(beat)
Memory is.

The screen behind her glitches, then cuts to black.

STATIC. Silence.

CUT TO:

INT. NOCTURNE - SUBTERRANEAN COUNCIL CHAMBER - NIGHT

A black chamber with lacquered walls that reflect no light. Ancient, silent, pressurized with ceremony. A long obsidian table stretches through the room like a wound.

Rei stands at one end, composed but unsteady. Before him, HOLOGRAPHIC SIGILS rotate in silent orbit. Each one linked to a voice, disembodied, ageless.

THE MUKUROKAI SHADOW BOARD.

Ten voices. No faces. Old dialects, Kansai, Edo, Kyushu, fractured beneath layers of modulation. They speak not in unison, but as a ritual echo.

MUKUROKAI VOICES
(overlapping)
Subject Kurokami has glitched protocol. Compromised ritual. Defiled code.

REI
You taught us the protocol was sacred.

MUKUROKAI VOICES
And sacred things must not bleed.

A pause. Then a final sigil lights up.

Different.

A SYMBOL, bone-white. Ornate. Older than the others.

Rei flinches.

A SCREEN flickers to life. But what appears isn't a face.

It's a RENDITION, ink-stroke shadows. Flowing calligraphy that forms and reforms. A MASK of God and Ghost.

THE ANCESTRAL PRESENCE. Its voice is soft. Feminine. But it folds over itself with centuries of weight.

ANCESTRAL PRESENCE (V.O.)
She remembers.

REI
That doesn't make her dangerous. It makes her... real.

ANCESTRAL PRESENCE (V.O.)
Order cannot glitch. Only reality can.

Rei's hands clench. His breath tightens.

MUKUROKAI VOICES
Authorize Black Protocol.

One by one, the sigils flicker RED. Voting. Not with urgency, with inevitability.

REI
You made her.

ANCESTRAL PRESENCE (V.O.)
We curated her. Like a disease curates immunity.

REI
She was a child.

ANCESTRAL PRESENCE (V.O.)
So were we all, before pain became clarity.

Rei trembles, but not only in fear.

REI
You erased entire bloodlines in the Meiji Restoration, and now a girl terrifies you?

The Presence pauses.

ANCESTRAL PRESENCE (V.O.)
We bled into every dynasty. Every ministry. Even emperors bowed, eventually.
(beat)
We restructured Japan four times. Every purge. Every rebirth. She's just a deeper cut.

The FINAL SIGIL turns red.

BLACK PROTOCOL: AUTHORIZED.

The screen glows blood-bright. Then fades.

Rei stands in silence.

REI
I was loyal.

ANCESTRAL PRESENCE (V.O.)
Loyalty is not divinity.

MUKUROKAI VOICES
Black Protocol confirmed.

Behind him, ritualists in white move like breathless ghosts. One hands him a file, the kill directive.

He doesn’t open it.

He doesn’t have to.

His reflection on the obsidian table, fractured. Split. Unwhole.

INT. MUKUROKAI ARCHIVE — UNKNOWN LOCATION

A shrine of violence. Blades preserved in glass. Scrolls inked in blood. A library of erasure. Ancient contracts singed into silk. Hair samples pressed into lacquer.

On the back wall, a sprawling TAPESTRY, each panel stitched with historical scenes.

- Samurai bowing before a faceless tribunal.

- Court nobles vanishing from woodblock prints.

- Early surveillance diagrams drawn in calligraphy.

- Executions beneath cherry blossoms, then corporate towers rising over the same soil.

THE ANCESTRAL PRESENCE watches.

Not through a screen.

Through a MIRROR.

Ritualists in bone-white robes encircle a kneeling WOMAN, unnamed, compliant. Her lips are painted black. Her chest bare. Her eyes closed, not in fear, in worship.

One ritualist moves behind her. Removes his mask.

It’s Rei.

He kneels too. Opposite her.

His hand trembles as he holds the blade, obsidian, curved, ancient.

The woman opens her eyes. Looks into his. She smiles.

WOMAN
May my death restore the balance.

REI
May your memory never glitch.

He kisses her, soft, reverent, holy.

Then draws the blade across her throat with agonizing grace.

Blood spills like ink across sacred parchment.

The ritualists bow.

The mirror doesn’t blink.

ANCESTRAL PRESENCE (V.O.)
Order is not eternal. It is maintained.

Rei’s face is sprayed with red.

He doesn’t flinch.

Because now, he believes.

CUT TO:

EXT. NOCTURNE PERIMETER - NIGHT

A void between structures, where security lights fail and shadows cling like second skin.

Akira walks. Hood up. Barefoot. She’s silent. Too silent.

A soft metallic hiss.

Something stabs her neck.

A TRANQ DART.

Her body jerks. Legs falter. She stumbles forward, catching herself on the slick steel wall.

A SHADOW emerges.

MASKED. WHITE UNIFORM. Surgical gloves. Precise. Cold.

He doesn’t speak. He doesn’t need to. Two more appear.

She’s surrounded.

Her breath shortens. Blood blooms down her spine.

Her knees hit the concrete. They approach, not with cruelty, but ritual calm.

HOODED AGENT 1
(softly)
We honor the glitch.

HOODED AGENT 2
And restore order.

They draw a needle, not to sedate. To STOP the heart.

Akira's eyes flutter. Limbs weak. But not gone.

Then- a hand grabs one of the agents.

SNAP. His neck breaks. Fast. Clean.

It's Yumi. Her hair wild. Her eyes wet with terror. She's not trained for this, but she's decided.

YUMI
No.

Agent 2 lunges. Yumi throws herself forward. A knife misses her cheek by millimeters, she twists, kicks desperate, ungraceful.

Akira's hand twitches. Twitch becomes flex.

Then- VIOLENCE.

Her body moves without thought. No strategy. No technique.

She BITES. Deep into Agent 3's throat, a wet snap of cartilage.

He gurgles. She doesn't stop.

Her teeth come away painted red.

She rises, blood dripping from her chin.

Eyes dead.

Yumi watches, frozen. Horrified. Aroused. Something primal flickers.

Agent 2 goes for a weapon, Akira catches his wrist.

BREAKS IT. Bone cracks through skin.

She spins him into the wall. Elbow. Knee. Eyes.

Every blow is survival. But it's also release.

She STRADDLES him, pins him.

Then, with no expression, she pushes her fingers into his windpipe.

Until he stops.

No one speaks. Just panting. Dripping. Blood pools like ink.

Yumi steps forward.

AKIRA (V.O.)
The first time you kill, they say you feel it forever.

Akira stares at her hands.

AKIRA (V.O.)
They're wrong.

A bead of blood trails down her thigh. Erotic. Horrific.

Yumi kneels. Slowly. Offers her hand, not in comfort. In submission.

Akira doesn't take it.

But she doesn't look away.

CUT TO:

INT. HIDDEN BATHING CHAMBER - NIGHT

Red-lit. Geothermal steam. Ancient stone basin cut into the earth itself. A forgotten purification room deep beneath Nocturne, sacred, untouched by surveillance.

Yumi enters first. Holding Akira's hand.

Akira is still bleeding, slow, dried streaks across her thigh. She doesn't flinch.

YUMI
(quietly)
No one comes here anymore. Not since they automated cleansing.

She seals the door. A hiss. Everything goes still.

Akira steps forward, unspeaking.

Yumi approaches, slowly. She unclasps Akira's belt. Lets it fall.

The robe slips. Silence. Skin, marbled in scar tissue and steam. Battle and obedience painted across her.

Yumi kneels.

She begins to wash Akira with a ceremonial cloth. Ritualistic. Erotic. Reverent.

WATER pours from a bamboo spout, steaming. Every breath sounds louder. Every gesture, intentional.

YUMI (CONT'D)
(whispering)
Let me remember you this time.

Akira's hand moves, slowly, to lift Yumi's chin. They stare into each other.

AKIRA
Then don't look away.

Their mouths meet. Not desperate, but deep. The kind of kiss that could resurrect a person.

Hands wander. Steam licks skin. Akira's breath breaks. Yumi exhales into her mouth.

They move together, into the water.

INT. STONE BATH - CONTINUOUS

Their bodies submerge. Languid. Yumi straddles Akira, not with dominance, but presence.

Water ripples. Fingers trace scars. Every kiss is placed like a memory being stitched.

Yumi moves slowly. Deliberately. Akira arches, not in performance, but release.

Steam fogs everything. Except their eyes. Locked.

YUMI
Say my name.

AKIRA
(softly)
You don't need it. I remember you.

They climax, together. Not loud. Not frantic. But like breath held for years finally exhaled.

INT. POST-BATH - LATER

Akira lies on the stone floor. Damp. Spent. Alive.

Yumi rests her head on Akira's chest. Listening to the heart she helped quiet.

They don't speak.

They don't need to.

CUT TO:

INT. HIDDEN BATH CHAMBER - NOCTURNE - CONTINUOUS

Steam coils like breath through red-lit stone. The air hums with heat.

Akira stands in the shallows. Ink bottle in hand. Still damp from the ritual with Yumi. Her hair clings to her shoulders. Her body — ritual-marked, not broken.

Yumi kneels behind her. Quiet. Watching. Reverent.

She dips her fingers into the ink. Black as void.

YUMI
(softly)
You don't have to do this alone.

AKIRA
I'm not.

Yumi begins painting. Slow, deliberate strokes across Akira's back. Down her spine. Symbols lost to formal language, older than programming.

Akira breathes in. Deep.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
Thank you.

Yumi says nothing. But her fingers tremble. One last stroke.

She steps back. A final look.

YUMI
Remember who you are.

Akira turns, meets her eyes.

AKIRA
I will.

Yumi exits. Silent. The door slides closed, leaving Akira in the hush of steam and sacred heat.

INT. THE NAMING CHAMBER - MINUTES LATER

A stone circle. Empty but for her.

Akira steps in. Completely nude. No covering. No armor. Ink-slick and glistening.

Before her, a basin of ink. A blade. A mirror.

She kneels.

Breathes.

Lifts the blade.

Slow. Purposeful. Not self-harm. Self-claiming.

She carves the kanji into her thigh, 黒神 - Kurokami.

She exhales, not in pain. In clarity.

Blood mixes with ink.

She stands. Walks to the mirror.

Her reflection, raw, marked, real.

She stares. Unblinking.

A flicker behind her. Lights meant to detect movement, don't.

She is no longer a glitch. She is a ghost with a name.

AKIRA (V.O.)
Not theirs.

She walks away. Leaving bloody footprints that vanish in the steam.

AKIRA (V.O.)
Mine.

CUT TO:

INT. RITUAL CHAMBER — NIGHT

Stone and shadow. The walls pulse with low amber light. A ceremonial stillness lingers, like the room is holding its breath.

Rei stands alone, clad in black silk robes. Regal. Composed. Waiting.

The double doors open.

Akira enters, bare-armed, inked, unblinking.

REI
(firm but quiet)
You look like prophecy. But I wonder if you understand what that costs.

AKIRA
It cost everything.

REI
No. It gifted clarity.
(beat)
You didn’t break the system. You completed its loop.

Akira steps closer. The ink on her skin glistens.

REI (CONT’D)
We don’t need to erase you now. We can elevate you. Name you. Seat you beside us.

He gestures behind him, a raised dais with a vacant black cushion. Untouched.

REI (CONT’D)
No more rooms. No more numbers. You become the code.

She watches him. Still.

REI (CONT’D)
And I will kneel with you, in worship, in power. As we rewrite the future from the inside.

He begins to disrobe.

First the robe. Then the sash. Each movement deliberate. Sensual. Reverent.

REI (CONT’D)
No more obedience. Just evolution. Just us.

He steps toward her, bare-chested. Vulnerable but unashamed.

REI (CONT’D)
Let me show you what surrender means when no one’s watching.

He leans in, a kiss offered without demand. She lets him.

Their lips touch. Soft. Slow. Charged with the tension of belief.

Then-

AKIRA
(whispered, into his mouth)
You smell like failure.

She pulls back.

Rei stands, exposed. Still reaching.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
You don't get to name me.

She turns.

Walks.

Each step echoes like a verdict.

The chamber dims.

Rei watches her disappear into shadow.

He exhales. Just once. Almost a sob.

Then silence.

He walks to the black cushion. Kneels. Alone.

REI
(softly, to no one)
I was the last to survive the Meiji purge. I thought that meant I deserved to stay.

His reflection in the polished obsidian tiles flickers.

Erased before the breath leaves him.

He opens a ceremonial drawer beneath the dais.

A single object, a ritual blade. Sheathed in white silk.

He places it before him. Bows his head.

REI (CONT'D)
You are what I couldn't become.

CUT TO:

INT. GLASS CORRIDOR — MOMENTS LATER

Akira walks. Alone. Holy.

She is not untouchable.

She is becoming.

CUT TO:

INT. CONTROL NEXUS - NIGHT

A circular chamber. Hollowed from obsidian and screenlight. No visible entrance, only light and hum.

Akira stands at the core, cloaked in ceremonial black. Ink stains her thighs. Her fingers tremble not from fear. From purpose.

Before her, the PRIMARY TERMINAL. A forgotten relic. Keyed only to those who were never meant to survive.

She places her palm on the screen. Blood. Ink. Memory.

THE SYSTEM STALLS.

Then it breathes.

INT. VARIOUS - SIMULTANEOUS

SCREENS FLICKER TO LIFE, across NOCTURNE.

— A training ward. Nurses freeze.

— A sleep chamber. Subjects stir, blinking.

— A glass corridor. Lights dim. Then pulse.

INT. HALL OF REPROCESSING - NIGHT

Yumi stares at a blank monitor, until it floods with light.

ON THE SCREEN: AKIRA. Younger. Crying. Then still. Then stripped. Then stitched.

Voices whisper, then crescendo into layered poetry.

AKIRA (V.O.)
I was born twice. Once in silence. Once in surveillance. I was never asked. I was only catalogued.

INT. CONTROL NEXUS - CONTINUOUS

Akira types. Keys bleed. Her skin radiates.

AKIRA (V.O.)
And yet, I remember. Every touch. Every absence. Memory is not betrayal. It is rebellion.

She uploads the FULL FILE.

GRAPHIC DATA floods the air, not pornographic, but POETIC. Ghostlike overlays of: Akira learning to obey. Akira learning to fake it. Akira, watching herself vanish in a mirror.

INT. SURVEILLANCE FLOOR - NIGHT

An OVERSEER slams keys, but the system won't obey.

OVERSEER
We've lost lockdown.

TECH (O.S.)
She's inside all of it.

INT. MEMORY ROOM - NIGHT

A REMEMBERER stares at the screen. Her lip trembles. Then, she SMILES.

INT. RITUAL DORMITORY - NIGHT

A dozen subjects rise from beds. Simultaneous. One starts to WEEP. Another LAUGHS.

A young man carves a single word into his palm, REAL.

INT. CONTROL NEXUS - CONTINUOUS

Akira's body trembles. Not in pain, in completion.

AKIRA (V.O.)
If they taught us to forget, then remembering is war.

The SYSTEM GLITCHES.

All screens flicker to BLACK.

Then one line of red code bleeds across every surface, 黒神.

INT. OBSERVATION CHAMBER - UNKNOWN

The ANCESTRAL PRESENCE watches.

No emotion. Just stillness.

For the first time, the mirror fogs.

CUT TO:

INT. NOCTURNE - MAIN SERVER CHAMBER - NIGHT

Alarms blare. Red strobes slice through the dark like a heartbeat. Heat distortion ripples the air.

THE KUROKAMI BROADCAST still pulses across screens. Akira's memories. Her body. Her truth.

INT. MUKUROKAI CONTROL NEXUS - SAME

White-clad technicians SCREAM into comms. One slits his own throat with a ritual blade, blood on screens.

A CONTROL BOARD flashes an ancient override: KAGUTSUCHI PROTOCOL — ENGAGED.

INT. NOCTURNE — SUBLEVELS - CONTINUOUS

Flames bloom from the walls. Precision charges.

Ancient vents hiss molten steam. Collapse is coming.

INT. SURVEILLANCE HALL - CONTINUOUS

Yumi watches through static-laced feeds. Her face, bloodied, burned, alive.

She SLAMS a palm to the emergency override.

YUMI
(to the survivors)
Follow me. NOW.

INT. WARD CORRIDOR - MOMENTS LATER

Naked, trembling REMEMBERERS stumble through firelit halls. Yumi leads. A child clutches her hand.

INT. CORE CHAMBER — SIMULTANEOUS

Akira stands, center-frame. Flames behind her. Cables hanging like veins. Her skin is charred and inked.

But her broadcast continues.

Her image dances across a THOUSAND SCREENS. A woman kneels, sobbing. A nurse lets go of a scalpel. A boy watches. And remembers.

INT. UNKNOWN ARCHIVE - INTERCUT

THE ANCESTRAL PRESENCE flickers on a shattered screen, calligraphy dissolving in heat.

ANCESTRAL PRESENCE (V.O.)
She is not a glitch. She is a wound.

INT. SERVER CHAMBER — FINAL MOMENTS

The flames curl toward Akira. She does not flinch.

AKIRA (V.O.)
This isn’t revolution.

It’s recollection.

She closes her eyes. Her lips part. Her body becomes silhouette, flame-wrapped, holy.

The screen behind her glitches-

BLACK.

SILENCE.

CUT TO:

INT. SUBTERRANEAN VENT SHAFT — MOMENTS LATER

Yumi shoves open a rusted hatch. Smoke pours. Survivors collapse into moonlight. Coughing. Gasping.

But alive.

Yumi turns, the fire behind her like a funeral for gods.

YUMI
(whispers)
You saved them.

She steps into the ash.

CUT TO:

INT. NOCTURNE - OUTER CORRIDOR — NIGHT

Smoke coils in the air. Lights flicker, fading embers of a system in collapse.

Yumi stands still.

Her hair is wet. Her lip split. Her white coat darkened with soot.

Behind her, survivors. Silent. Staggered. Rememberers. The almost-erased.

She doesn’t lead them. She simply... doesn’t leave.

From down the corridor, FOOTSTEPS.

Then- a figure appears.

AKIRA.

Steam rising off her like a ghost escaping flesh. Her eyes glowing with something not divine, but awakened.

They stop before one another.

YUMI
(still)
It’s done?

AKIRA
No. But it begins.

Their hands meet. No kiss. Just contact. Like passing a torch or a memory.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
You end it. Your way.

Yumi's eyes shine, not from hope. From pain. Earned.

AKIRA turns- and walks.

EXT. TOKYO — PRE-DAWN

A soft wind stirs. The city glows from neon, ash and memory.

Akira walks through the streets. Past glass. Past metal. Past eyes that now see her.

A child looks up from a screen and the screen glitches. A REMEMBERING.

A flower seller bows in recognition.

Akira doesn't wave. Doesn't pause.

She fades into the thinning night.

Her body vanishes in silhouette, swallowed by the pulse of the waking world.

But her presence... remains.

AKIRA (V.O.)
They taught us that silence keeps us safe.

But memory... keeps us whole.

FADE OUT.

TEXT ON SCREEN:

KUROKAMI — BLACK GODDESS

She was never a ghost. Only a name... they tried to forget.

FADE TO BLACK.